

The Dhāraṇī Called 'The Mother of Noble Avalokiteśvara'

Ārya-Avalokiteśvara-mātā-nāma-dhāraṇī · Toh 725 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་སྐྱ་རས་གཟགིས་དབང་ཕྱག་གི་ཡིམ་ཞེས་བ་བྱའཁོའ་བྱུངས།

Toh 725 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī text known in Sanskrit as the Ārya-Avalokiteśvara-mātā-nāma-dhāraṇī and in Tibetan as the Phagpa Chenrezik Wangchuk gi Yum zhes bya ba'i Zung, meaning "The Dhāraṇī Called The Mother of Noble Avalokiteśvara." As a dhāraṇī scripture, it belongs to the broad category of tantric or ritual literature focused on sacred mantra formulas, and its title links it to Avalokiteśvara, the great bodhisattva of compassion, framing the dhāraṇī as a kind of feminine or generative source associated with him. The text opens in the manner of a sūtra, with the Buddha residing in Vaiśālī amid a vast assembly of monks and bodhisattvas, and it is the bodhisattva Samantabhadra who rises to prompt the teaching. It is preserved in the Dhāraṇī section of the Kangyur as Toh 725.

In the language of India: Ārya-Avalokiteśvara-mātā-nāma-dhāraṇī. In the language of Tibet: The dhāraṇī called "The Mother of Noble Avalokiteśvara."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was in the city of Vaiśālī, surrounded by a great retinue and facing them: five hundred fully ordained monks, the great śrāvakas headed by Śāriputra, and Maitreya and others — very many great bodhisattvas, great beings — surrounding him and facing him, while the Blessed One sat upon a prepared seat.

In that assembly there was present a great bodhisattva, a great being, named Samantabhadra. He rose from his own seat, arranged his outer robe over one shoulder, set his right knee upon the ground, bowed his head to the feet of the Blessed One, and spoke to the Blessed One as follows.

"Blessed One, this great vidyā-mantra — the mantra-foundation of the dhāraṇī called 'The Mother of Avalokiteśvara' — was proclaimed in the past, is proclaimed in the present, and will be proclaimed in the future by all buddha Blessed Ones. Blessed One, when you were a bodhisattva and were fully seeking awakening, it was proclaimed before in order to take care of all sentient beings, for their benefit and for the benefit of bodhisattvas. For the sons and daughters of the family of the Mahāyāna who have gone far away or

come near, who are without refuge — it becomes their refuge; for those without allies — it becomes their ally; for those without protector — it becomes their protector; and it exhausts all misdeeds. The moment this dhāraṇī is heard, all aspirations will be completely fulfilled, and all vidyā-mantras will be accomplished."

The Blessed One then declared: "Great bodhisattva, great being, when I had formerly become a bodhisattva and was fully seeking awakening, in a world-realm beyond world-realms as numerous as the sands of the Ganges River, and yet further beyond even those — in a world-realm called Sukhāvatī — there dwells even now the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha named Amitābha, living, present, and teaching the Dharma. In that very assembly there was present a bodhisattva who had attained the third bodhisattva ground, named the brahmin Śrī-Prabhā. He proclaimed, explained, and taught this dhāraṇī — this great queen of vidyā-mantras — the dhāraṇī called 'The Mother of Avalokiteśvara' — to many thousands of brahmins and to many tens of millions of sentient beings. I recall that the moment all of them heard this dhāraṇī, they were liberated from all misdeeds and transgressions, and they recalled their former births. Let that great bodhisattva, great being, now speak. In a future time, throughout all world-realms afflicted by defilements, for sentient beings who commit misdeeds, who commit the boundless transgressions — many tens of millions of times hundreds of thousands of misdeeds will be exhausted. They will come to have benefit and happiness. They will become the protector of those without protector. I too give my approval and rejoice."

The Blessed One then declared: "Thereupon the great bodhisattva, the great being Samantabhadra, spoke these words — the mantra-foundation of the great vidyā-mantra of the dhāraṇī called 'The Mother of Avalokiteśvara.'"

Homage to the Three Jewels. Homage to the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Amitābha.

Homage to the noble bodhisattva, the great being, the lord Avalokiteśvara, who is endowed with great compassion. Having paid homage to him, one should recite the following — the mantra-foundation of the great vidyā-mantra of the dhāraṇī called "The Mother of Avalokiteśvara":

"May this vidyā be accomplished in me. tadyathā — ili mili, cili mili, kuntule kuntule, sire si sire, bisire, birāyā gauri, gandhari drāmaṭe, mātaṅgi, pukkāsi, kaṣṭāya, mācaṇḍālī, huṭṭumālinī, hūṃ dhudhu mālinī, cile mile, grhṇa

saumyadarśani, kuru candramukhe, lāghūmānayaṃte, āryādakṣibhuje
sarvavidyānām prasādhane sarvavidyānām īśvari svāhā."

The ritual of this dhāraṇī — which is accomplished through recitation — is as follows: the very moment it is heard, all karmic obscurations are purified. It protects from all fears. If it is recited three times a day for seven days, one will behold the great bodhisattva, the great being Samantabhadra. If one recites it with a mind undistracted by anything else, then within one month the great vidyā (mahāvidyā) of the noble Avalokiteśvara herself will appear in person, and one will also behold the noble Amitābha. One will become irreversible from unsurpassed awakening. One will also come to remember past lives and to retain what one hears. In whatever birth and wherever one is born, one will never be separated from the sacred Dharma. One will come to have great prosperity.

When the Blessed One had thus declared this, the great bodhisattva Samantabhadra, together with those bodhisattvas, those monks, and that entire assembled retinue, rejoiced and praised the words of the Blessed One.

The dhāraṇī called "The Mother of Avalokiteśvara" is complete.

The Indian pandita Jinamitra and —

Translator's Notes

- The phrase rendered "boundless transgressions" refers to the ānantarya — the five heinous acts of immediate karmic consequence — though the Tibetan here uses "མཐོང་སྤྱོད་ཀླུ་རྒྱལ་གྱི་འཛུགས་པོ།" more generally for any such grave transgression. The note is doctrinal rather than translational.

The figure "the brahmin Śrī-Prabhā" renders "ब्रह्मविष्णुशिवप्रभुः" — literally "the brahmin Powerful-Light" — which appears to be a proper name combining two Sanskrit elements, plausibly Śrī-Prabhā or Tejahprabhā; the exact Sanskrit reconstruction is uncertain.

- The text breaks off mid-sentence with "The Indian paṇḍita Jinamitra and —" which is the standard colophon formula naming the translators; the passage ends here because the source excerpt is incomplete at that point.

The phrase rendered "the great vidyā of the noble Avalokiteśvara herself will appear in person" translates "ॐ अहं विद्यायां भगवते अवलोकितेश्वरानामिदं विद्यादेवमस्मिन् भगवते विद्यायां भगवते अवलोकितेश्वरानामिदं विद्यादेवमस्मिन्" — here ॐ अहं विद्यायां भगवते अवलोकितेश्वरानामिदं विद्यादेवमस्मिन् is used in the sense of mahāvidyā (the great vidyā, the mantra-deity herself) rather than its more common doctrinal sense of "great ignorance." This is a well-attested usage in dhāraṇī literature where the feminine vidyā-deity is personified, and the grammar (अहं विद्यायां भगवते अवलोकितेश्वरानामिदं विद्यादेवमस्मिन्, "reveals herself") confirms this reading.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.